

The Complete Financial Guide for Young Couples

I suggest a quarterly clothes budget be allocated and then allow the teenagers to select their own wardrobe. Obviously, the parents need to establish some fundamental rules regarding modesty, price, and style. But the decision about where to shop and what to buy should be the teenagers'. There are some hazards in yielding this authority, but you need to bear in mind that as parents, you are raising future adults who will eventually have the sole right to make these decisions.

It's always enlightening to see earlier evaluations being revealed in your children's buying habits. It often helps parents to focus on weak areas, as well as strengths, in their children.

I recall the example of two teenagers whose parents decided to give them total responsibility for buying their clothes. They spent several hours discussing where to find the best buys, how to pick quality clothes, and so on. Then one fateful summer day, Mom dropped them off in the shopping mall with about \$200 each to buy school clothes.

The oldest son, about 16 and very conservative, bought exactly what they had discussed: tennis shoes, jeans, shirts, underwear, et cetera. The younger son, about 13 and very strong-willed, bought a couple of pairs of socks, a silk-screened T-shirt, and a *very* expensive skateboard. Later that evening during their family time, his father said, "Rick, we gave you the right and responsibility to make your own decisions about what clothes to buy. Just remember, no more clothes money for at least three months."

Rick replied, "Don't you worry, Dad. I've got plenty of clothes for school."

Over the next couple of weeks Rick succeeded in virtually destroying his pants, shirts, and shoes practicing on his new skateboard. About three days before school was to start, Rick came downstairs to where his dad was reading and said, "Dad, I have a problem. I can't go to school like this." He showed his tennis shoes with toes sticking out of them.

Rick's dad replied, "Oh, that's really a shame. You're right. You can't go to school like that." And with that, he got some black electrical tape and wrapped it around Rick's shoes. After